Svarupa Damodara Gosvami

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The Lord's “Second Self”

Of all who surrounded Sri Chaitanya in Puri, none was as close to His heart as Svarupa Damodara. When Krishnadasa Kaviraja Gosvami first brings him into the story, he speaks of him thus:

“The next day Svarupa Damodara arrived, whose heart was like a boundless ocean of rasa. He was a very close friend of Sri Chaitanya.” (CC, Madhya 10.102)

And a little further on:

“He had deeply realized the essence of Krishna-rasa and had become the very embodiment of that divine love. At times he was called a manifestation of the spiritual nature of Mahaprabhu Himself.” (CC, Madhya 10.111)

That is why the Vaishnavas call him Gaurasundara's “second self” (dvitiya-svarupa): the Lord's most intimate confidant, the keeper of His secret moods, prema-rasa itself in the form of a devotee.

Purushottama Acharya of Navadvipa

Before sannyasa he was called Purushottama Acharya; he is sometimes also called Purushottama Bhattacharya. Little is known of his family. His father was Padmagarbha Acharya, a learned pandita; his mother, whose name has not come down to us, was the daughter of Jayarama Chakravarti. Jayarama lived in Bhitadia on the Brahmaputra (now in Bangladesh); later he moved with his family to Navadvipa, gave his daughter in marriage to Padmagarbha and brought his son-in-law to live with him. Soon after the birth of the son Padmagarbha left his wife and child in his father-in-law's house and went away to study in Mithila and then in Kashi, so Purushottama grew up in Navadvipa, in the home of his maternal grandparents. The “Prema-vilasa” adds that in Kashi Padmagarbha received initiation from Lakshmipati, the guru of Madhavendra Puri, and that by other wives he had further sons, among them Lakshminatha Lahiri, Svarupa's half-brother.

The same “Prema-vilasa” relates that Purushottama, a treasury of every virtue, lived with his mother in Navadvipa and became a beloved devotee of Chaitanya; he was well versed in the shastras, and everyone called him Acharya (“Prema-vilasa,” 24.536–537). While Gaurasundara was performing His pastimes in Navadvipa, Purushottama Acharya lived at His feet. Already then Mahaprabhu, seeing his extraordinary gift as a singer, gave him the name “Damodara.”

Sannyasa in Kashi

When Mahaprabhu accepted sannyasa, Purushottama, seeing it, became as if mad with separation. He went to Kashi (Varanasi)[1] and there he too took sannyasa, from a sannyasi named Chaitanyananda Bharati. His guru taught him Vedanta and told him to explain it to everyone. Sannyasa gave him the name “Svarupa,” and together with the name the Lord had given him he came to be called Damodara-Svarupa, or Svarupa Damodara. The “Prema-vilasa” calls him “the Lord's most intimate devotee, an ocean of rasa” (24.539).

This sannyasa was not a step taken for standing in an ashrama. His heart was full of separation, and he wanted only one thing — to serve Krishna free of hindrance and care:

“A strong longing arose in him to worship Krishna without any disturbance or obstacle, and therefore, guided by this half-mad feeling, he accepted sannyasa. Though, following tradition, he gave up the

shikha and the sacred thread, he did not accept saffron cloth, but only changed his name to ‘Svarupa.’” (CC, Madhya 10.107–108)

According to the rules of the Dashanami sannyasis he went through the rites of renunciation: he performed the eight shraddhas and the viraja-homa and gave up the shikha and the sacred thread. But he did not accept the yogapatta, nor the rite of invoking the guru (gurv-ahvana), nor a sannyasa name and danda. That is why the brahmachari name “Svarupa” stayed with him; had he accepted the yogapatta, it would have been replaced by the sannyasa title “Tirtha.” Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati explains that in the Tirtha and Ashrama lines of the Dashanamis candidates receive a brahmachari title with a vow of lifelong celibacy; “Svarupa” was such a title, and brahmacharis bearing it usually become “Tirthas” once they accept saffron or the yogapatta[2]. So he stopped at outward renunciation, without taking on the marks of sannyasa. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” says that the Lord “through Ramananda revealed the crushing of Kandarpa's pride, through Damodara revealed impartiality, through Haridasa showed forbearance, through Sanatana and Rupa revealed humility” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 1.630–631).

He was an eternally perfect devotee, peerless in the science of music and in the shastras alike; supremely detached and learned, he took shelter of Krishna with body and mind. He wrote a separate treatise on music, the “Sangita-damodara.”

Return to the Lord

The Lord accepted sannyasa on the full moon of Magha, came to Nilachala in Phalguna, and in Vaishakha set out on His pilgrimage to the south. When He returned, the first to come to Him from Bengal were Paramananda Puri and the brahmana Kamalakanta, and soon after them Svarupa Damodara. With his guru's permission he left Kashi and came to Purushottama.

Coming before Mahaprabhu, he prostrated himself, embraced His feet and recited a verse — a prayer for Sri Chaitanya's mercy:

“O ocean of mercy, Sri Chaitanya! The manifestation of Your compassion easily frees the heart from the dust of mental agitation, and so the heart is very quickly cleansed of all impurity. Then, in the purified heart, the rapturous birth of the highest devotion to Sri Krishna takes place. <…> O boundless kindness, Sri Chaitanya! When will Your all-auspicious mercy touch me?” (CC, Madhya 10.119; “Chaitanya-chandrodaya,” 8.10)

Gaurasundara raised His eternal “second self” from the ground and embraced him, and at that touch both fell unconscious in loving rapture. Coming to Himself, the Lord said, “Today I saw in a dream that you would come. It is good that you have come: I was as if blind, and with you I have regained My sight.” Svarupa answered with repentance:

“Prabhu! Forgive me my offense. I went away and left You, and that was a great mistake. There is not a trace of love for Your lotus feet in me. Were it otherwise, how could I have gone away? I am sinful and have no excuse. I left You, but You did not forget me. With the rope of Your mercy You pulled me by the neck back to Your feet.” (CC, Madhya 10.123–125)

The Lord embraced him again and said, “Krishna is merciful: by His mercy we have met again.”

Then Svarupa bowed at the feet of Nityananda, who embraced him with love; he bowed to Paramananda Puri and met Jagadananda, Mukunda, Shankara, Sarvabhauma and the other devotees. Mahaprabhu gave him a secluded dwelling and a servant to carry water and help with other needs. From then on he settled in Nilachala for good, to serve the Lord.

Soon, at the Lord's wish, Ramananda Raya too gave up the king's service and came to Nilachala; it was then that Svarupa met him[3]. Svarupa and Sarvabhauma, both former residents of Navadvipa, now lived

in Purushottama as kshetra-sannyasis, and both were bound to Ramananda by an eternal friendship; Svarupa and Ramananda were even called “one soul.”

Singer and Guardian of Siddhanta

The Lord regarded Svarupa as His intimate and entrusted him with a special service: to examine everything brought for Him to hear.

“If anyone wished to present his book, poem or song to Mahaprabhu, Svarupa Damodara first examined it, and only then would Sri Chaitanya agree to hear it. Sri Chaitanya did not wish to hear anything that contradicted the conclusions of Vaishnava siddhanta or contained rasabhasa, an incompatibility of spiritual moods.” (CC, Madhya 10.112–113)

Rasabhasa and deviation from siddhanta pained the Lord and roused His anger; so only what Svarupa had approved reached His ears.

Svarupa himself delighted the Lord with the songs of Vidyapati and Chandidasa and Jayadeva's “Gita-govinda.” Krishnadasa Kaviraja continues:

“In singing and playing musical instruments he was like the heavenly gandharvas. In knowledge of the scriptures he was like Brihaspati himself, the guru of the gods. Svarupa Damodara possessed such outstanding qualities that no one could compare with him. He was very dear to Advaita and Sri Nityananda, and the very life of the whole community of devotees headed by Srivasa Thakura.” (CC, Madhya 10.116–117)

Vrindavana Dasa Thakura too glorifies him above all as a singer. As Gadadhara was the master of the “Bhagavatam,” so Svarupa was the master of kirtana; he sang alone while the Lord danced, and hearing his loud singing the Lord would lose outer consciousness and fall to the ground. “Whenever Svarupa Damodara sang the qualities of Krishna, who has no equal, Lord Gauranga began to dance in great bliss” (CB, Antya 10.37). Among the Lord's sannyasi companions none equalled him, and the Lord loved him just as He loved Paramananda Puri. These two — Svarupa and Paramananda Puri — were inseparable from Mahaprabhu and took up the danda for the sake of His pastimes in sannyasa; Puri was absorbed in meditation, Svarupa in kirtana, and “these two sannyasis were like the arms of Lord Chaitanya” (CB, Antya 10.49).

Krishnadasa Kaviraja, listing the branches of Chaitanya's tree in Puri, names the same two first: “two — Paramananda Puri and Svarupa Damodara — were Sri Chaitanya's very life and breath” (CC, Adi 10.124). When Sarvabhauma invited the Lord and ten sannyasis for a whole month, he gave the Lord five days, Paramananda Puri five, Svarupa four and the rest two each, and asked the Lord to come alone or with Svarupa. In the list of these ten sannyasi companions — Paramananda Puri, Svarupa, Brahmananda Puri, Brahmananda Bharati, Vishnu Puri, Keshava Puri, Krishnananda Puri, Nrisimha Tirtha, Sukhananda Puri and Satyananda Bharati — he is named second.

Welcoming the Bengalis and Cleaning the Gundicha

Before the Ratha-yatra the devotees came from Gauda, and the Lord sent Svarupa together with His servant Govinda to meet them with garlands and prasada. When the Lord Himself served them prasada and would not eat, and the devotees would not eat without Him, Svarupa persuaded Him to sit down to the meal with Nityananda; then Svarupa, Jagadananda, Damodara Pandita and others did the serving.

At that time the Lord told Vasudeva Datta that the two books He had brought from the south — the “Brahma-samhita” and the “Krishna-karnamrita” — were kept by Svarupa, and told him to take them from Svarupa and copy them (CC, Madhya 11.141–142).

Before the festival the Lord Himself washed the Gundicha temple together with Nityananda, Advaita, Bharati, Puri and Svarupa Damodara, while the others carried water. Then a simple-hearted devotee from Gauda poured water on the Lord's feet and drank it. The Lord, inwardly pleased, outwardly grew angry in order to uphold proper conduct in the temple; He called Svarupa and said, “Look what your Gaudiya has done: in the Lord's temple he washed My feet and drank the water!” Svarupa took the devotee by the neck and led him out of the Gundicha; the man came back, humbly begged forgiveness, and the Lord was pleased[4]. So a Vaishnava may seem stern, yet within he is always full of compassion.

With the words “your Gaudiya” the Lord proclaimed to all the Vaishnavas that all the Gaudiya Vaishnavas are under Svarupa and that he is their leader. Hence his title “Sri Madhva-Gaudiyeshvara,” “lord of the Madhva-Gaudiyas,” by which he is honored in the Vaishnava community.

When the cleaning was over, a great kirtana began. “Mahaprabhu dearly loved Svarupa Damodara's singing. When he sang, Sri Chaitanya always danced in bliss and leapt high” (CC, Madhya 12.141). In Puri Svarupa also took part in the water pastimes — at Narendra-sarovara during the Chandana-yatra and at Indradyumna after the cleaning of the Gundicha; there he and his friend Pundarika Vidyanidhi, laughing, splashed water on each other (CB, Antya 8.124).

The Ratha-yatra

At the Ratha-yatra the chief lead singers of the kirtana groups were Svarupa Damodara and Srivasa Pandita. At first there were four groups; in the first Svarupa sang and Advaita was the chief dancer. With the groups of Shantipura, Shrikhanda and Kulina there were seven, each with two drummers, and the Lord appeared in all of them at once — just as, Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura explains, Krishna appeared in the rasa dance. When the Lord wished to dance in full abandon, He brought the groups together and set Svarupa at the head of nine singers; Damodara Pandita too sang in his choir.

The Lord danced to his singing, and Svarupa understood His every sign and sang following the movements of His heart. The Lord was especially delighted by the song with the refrain “sei ta parana-natha painu / jaha lagi madana-dahane jhuri genu”:

“At last I have found again the Lord of My life! In separation from Him I pined with grief, burning from the arrows of love.” (CC, Madhya 13.113)

This song of meeting the Beloved after long separation, says Bhaktivinoda Thakura, came of itself to Svarupa's lips when at the end of the dance the Lord was absorbed in Radha's mood at Kurukshetra. For the Lord the temple of Jagannatha was Kurukshetra and the Gundicha was Vrindavana, and Svarupa understood everything He was experiencing at the Ratha-yatra.

Before Jagannatha the Lord, dancing, acted out the song with His hands. When Gaura stepped back, Shyama stopped; when He went forward, the chariot slowly moved forward: Gaurasundara, as it were, seated Shyamasundara on the chariot of His heart. Raising His arms, He recited again and again the verse “yah kaumara-harah….” This verse comes from the books on poetics (“Kavya-prakasha,” “Sahitya-darpana”; it is also in the “Padyavali”) and on the surface speaks of earthly lovers, but in the Lord's mouth it expressed the feeling of Radha meeting Krishna at Kurukshetra. No one but Svarupa knew its meaning, and day and night the Lord relished it alone with Svarupa.

Krishnadasa Kaviraja finds no words for Svarupa's happiness:

“Who can describe the great fortune of Svarupa Damodara, who in body, heart and words was wholly devoted to Sri Chaitanya? Their feelings were truly fused into one, and so the Lord listened to Svarupa Damodara's singing in self-forgetfulness. Sometimes Sri Chaitanya, overcome by intense prema, would sit on the road and, bending down, write something on it with His finger. Then Svarupa, fearing that the

Lord might hurt Himself, would carefully examine His hand. He was so sensitive to the slightest change in Sri Chaitanya's feelings that he could at once foresee their subtlest shade and instantly embody it in song.” (CC, Madhya 13.163–167)

Through Svarupa's senses the Lord Himself relished the singing, and Svarupa's kirtana gave form in the Lord's heart now to one, now to another feeling of Radha suffering in separation from Krishna.

Hera-panchami

On Hera-panchami, having returned from the Gundicha, the Lord asked Svarupa with a smile why Jagannatha, going to Sundarachala, whose groves resemble Vrindavana, does not take Lakshmi with Him. Svarupa answered that in the pastimes of Vrindavana there is no place for Lakshmi: there Krishna's companions are the gopis alone, and no one but they can steal His mind. “Then why is she so angry?” “Such is the nature of a loving woman: she cannot bear even a shadow of indifference from her beloved, and from this is born mana — the anger of loving pique.”

At that moment Lakshmi, in her anger, came out of the inner chambers to the Lion Gate — on a golden palanquin, under an umbrella, with chamaras and flags, with betel boxes and pitchers, to music, with dancing devadasis and hundreds of maidservants. Her maids seized the chief servants of Jagannatha and began to beat them, while the devotees laughed, covering their mouths. Svarupa, the first among the intimate devotees, said: “Such mana we have never heard of or seen in the three worlds. A piqued beloved loses her ardor, takes off her ornaments, sits on the ground with darkened face and draws lines on the earth with her nail. Such is the mana of the gopis of Vraja and even of Satyabhama, the lady of the city. But Lakshmi does the opposite: she has put her riches on show, gathered an army and marches to war against her beloved.”

The Lord began to question him about the kinds of mana in Vraja and heard from his lips the secret truths of Vraja-prema. Listening to Svarupa's explanation of Radha's feelings, He embraced him in rapture, and then asked again — about the vilasas and her other moods.

Here Srivasa Pandita joined in. He extolled the wealth of his Lakshmi and teased Vrindavana for its poverty and “your mistress” for churning butter. The Lord remarked that each has his own particular way of bhajana, and Svarupa answered with the natural wealth of Vrindavana: all the majesty of Maha-Vaikuntha is but a small part of it; there Krishna sets aside His majesty; there the trees are wish-fulfilling kalpa-vrikshas, the earth is chintamani, the water nectar, speech song, every step a dance, the flute a dear friend, and the Lakshmis there are countless and full of sweetness. This dispute is told more fully in the article on Srivasa Pandita.

Hearing from Svarupa's lips of the highest rasa of service to Radha, the Lord danced for joy. When Svarupa sang songs of Vraja-rasa, He kept saying, “Go on, go on!” and bent His ear to his lips, and a wave of divine love flooded all Purushottama.

Nilachala and the Road to Vrindavana

So in Nilachala the Lord lived with Puri Gosvami (Paramananda Puri), Svarupa, Jagadananda, Damodara Pandita, Govinda and Kashishvara, and every morning went for darshana of Jagannatha, while Gadadhara He had appointed to serve Gopinatha in Yameshvara-tota.

Svarupa was bound by friendship to Pundarika Vidyanidhi. Whenever Vidyanidhi came to Nilachala he stayed with Svarupa, and they talked of Krishna; Krishnadasa Kaviraja calls him Svarupa's close friend (CC, Madhya 16.77). Once, on Odana-shashthi, Pundarika disapproved that the pujaris dressed Jagannatha in starched cloth and asked Svarupa's opinion. Svarupa replied, “The Lord is independent and not subject to the rules of smriti.” “Jagannatha is independent, but the pujaris are not,” Pundarika

objected. That night Jagannatha and Balarama came to him in a dream and slapped his cheeks. Seeing his friend's swollen cheeks, Svarupa rejoiced at his good fortune:

“Listen, brother. I have never seen such an amazing punishment, nor heard of anything like it. The Lord came to you in a dream and punished you personally.” (CB, Antya 10.175–176)

On Vijaya-dashami the Lord set out for Vrindavana, and His chief companions were Puri Gosvami and Svarupa Damodara. That year He did not reach Vrindavana; He returned to Nilachala and began to think of going alone. The next year, after the Ratha-yatra, He made up His mind; Ramananda and Svarupa pleaded with Him at length and gave Him Balabhadra Bhattacharya and one servant as companions. In the morning the devotees, not finding the Lord, rushed in anguish to search for Him, but Svarupa held them back. And when the Lord came back from Vrindavana, Svarupa and others met Him at Narendra-sarovara, and he sent word of His return to Gauda.

Rupa's Verse

The secret meaning of the verse “yah kaumara-harah” was known to Svarupa alone, and he sang padas in the same mood, delighting the Lord. But in Puri Rupa Gosvami too caught this mood. He wrote on a palm leaf a verse revealing the true meaning of the verse and tucked the leaf under the thatch of his hut. The Lord came while Rupa was bathing in the sea, read it and was overwhelmed with ecstasy; when Rupa returned and prostrated himself, the Lord gave him an affectionate pat: “How did you know what is hidden in My heart?”

Then the Lord showed the verse to Svarupa and, as if not knowing the answer, asked how Rupa had entered into His thoughts. Svarupa replied:

“As I understand it, You are especially favorable to him. No one could grasp this secret meaning. I think You have fully endowed him with Your causeless mercy.” (CC, Antya 1.86–87)

And he added that the moment he saw the verse he understood it was anointed with the Lord's special mercy, for the cause is known by its effect.

Another time the Lord came with Svarupa, Ramananda and Sarvabhauma to Rupa, who was staying with Haridasa near the Siddha-bakula, and told him to recite his verse “priyah so 'yam…” — the very one that had been on the leaf (it is also given in the “Padyavali”). Rupa was silent out of reverence, so Svarupa recited the verse, astonishing everyone, and then explained that Rupa had understood the Lord's heart by His special mercy. Rupa became Svarupa's dear friend; later, speaking of worldly poets, Svarupa would hold up as an example the way Rupa had begun his two plays — and from this it is concluded that Rupa's plays were largely written while the Lord was still present.

In Puri Sanatana Gosvami too was introduced to Svarupa, as to all the devotees, and later Raghunatha Bhatta, when he first came to the Lord.

Against Mayavada

In Puri, near the Lord, lived Bhagavan Acharya — a learned Vaishnava, simple-hearted, in the mood of friendship, like a cowherd boy, though his father, Shatananda Khan, was a worldly man. He was Svarupa's friend. Bhagavan Acharya's younger brother, Gopala Bhattacharya, had studied Vedanta in Kashi, and Bhagavan Acharya suggested that Svarupa hear Shankara's “Shariraka-bhashya” from him. Svarupa answered with loving anger:

“In Gopala's company you have lost your reason. Forgetting the highest goal of life, you wish to hear the deceptive philosophy of Mayavada. Any Vaishnava who decides to study Shankaracharya's Mayavada commentary gradually breaks off his relationship with God, founded on the feeling of servant

and Master, and begins to think himself the Supreme. Hearing Shankara's Mayavada commentary defiles the heart even of the greatest Vaishnava, for whom Krishna is dearer than life itself, and as a result he will surely change all his convictions." (CC, Antya 2.94–96)

Bhagavan Acharya objected that a heart given to Krishna will not be shaken by any commentary. But Svarupa replied that one would still have to hear that Brahman is only impersonal spirit, the world a false illusion, the soul a fiction and God subject to ignorance — and such words break a devotee's heart. Bhagavan Acharya, abashed and frightened, fell silent, and the next day sent Gopala back to his home. So Svarupa, "the guru of all Vaishnavas," showed how one who seeks pure service to Krishna should regard the Mayavada commentary of Shankaracharya, the avatara who came to bewilder the asuras: the poison of Mayavada is so strong that once it enters the ears it inevitably ruins the soul.

He who would not yield a hair's breadth in siddhanta was gentle with devotees who had stumbled. When the Lord, to teach living beings, rejected His devotee Junior Haridasa (Chhota Haridasa), Svarupa and others asked the Lord the reason. Haridasa fasted for three days in grief, and Svarupa comforted him with the hope of seeing the Lord's feet again: "The Lord is independent, and now He is holding firm; later He will be merciful. If you persist, His persistence will only grow. Break your fast." Haridasa obeyed, but the Lord did not relent, and a year later Haridasa went to Prayaga and left his body there in the waters of the Triveni. Later Svarupa and other intimates heard his singing from afar without seeing the singer. Govinda and others supposed that Haridasa had taken his own life and become a brahma-rakshasa, but Svarupa, whose siddhanta the Lord always accepted, objected: "That is wrong. All his life he glorified Krishna and served the Lord, he was dear to Him, and he left his body in a holy place[5] — no evil could befall him. This is a wondrous pastime of the Lord; later you will understand" (CC, Antya 2.155–159). Krishnadasa Kaviraja writes of this:

"Then Svarupa Damodara and all the devotees gathered and concluded that, since Junior Haridasa had left his body at the holy confluence of three rivers, he had certainly attained the shelter of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu's lotus feet." (CC, Antya 2.166)

The Bengali Poet's Play

Once a brahmana poet from East Bengal, an acquaintance of Bhagavan Acharya, wrote a play about the Lord; the Vaishnavas praised it, and Bhagavan Acharya asked Svarupa to hear it before it was read to the Lord. Svarupa answered: "You are a cowherd boy, generous and ready to hear anything. In the words of an uninitiated poet there is rasabhasa. One who cannot tell rasa from rasabhasa and does not know grammar, rhetoric and the science of drama cannot describe Krishna's pastimes, still less the unfathomable pastimes of Chaitanya. Only one whose life is the feet of Gaura can describe the pastimes of Krishna and Gaura. A worldly poet's verses are painful to hear, while the words of a knowing devotee give joy — as with the way Rupa began his two plays."

For two or three days they pleaded with him, and at last he agreed. The poet read the opening nandi-shloka:

"Golden Sri Chaitanya has become the soul of the body of Sri Jagannatha, whose eyes are wide open like lotuses. He appeared in Jagannatha Puri and brought this lifeless nature to life. May this Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu grant you the highest fortune." (CC, Antya 5.112)

Svarupa told him to explain it, and the poet said: Jagannatha is the body and Sri Chaitanya the soul within that body; Jagannatha is merely a wooden image and Chaitanya His life: the Lord appeared in Nilachala to bring inert wood to life[6].

All the listeners were pleased; only Svarupa grew sad and said angrily:

“Fool! You have brought upon yourself a curse that will utterly ruin you. You have faith neither in Lord Jagannatha nor in Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu. Lord Sri Jagannatha is wholly spiritual and full of supreme bliss. Yet in your poetry you have presented Him as a lifeless, perishable body made of the Lord's external energy (prakriti). And Sri Chaitanya is the Supreme Himself, endowed with all six divine opulences. He is like the original supreme fire. But you have described Him as a mere spark — one of the multitude of ordinary souls. By offending Them both you have condemned yourself to hell! <…> In your verse you make a distinction between the body and the soul of God. And that is a grave offense! The soul and the body of God are one truth! There is no difference between them. Both His person and His body are the direct manifestation of the spiritual bliss of the Supreme Lord.” (CC, Antya 5.117–122)

Where is Krishna, the fullness of bliss and of all six opulences — and where the tiny soul, suffering in the service of maya!

The assembly was struck dumb. The poet stood ashamed, frightened and astonished, like a heron among swans. Seeing his distress, Svarupa softened and instructed him:

“Go and hear the message of the ‘Srimad-Bhagavatam’ from a true Vaishnava. You can do this only if you give yourself wholly to the feet of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu. Try to associate every day with Sri Chaitanya's devotees. Thus you will be able to feel and understand the waves of the ocean of the highest truths of devotion to God. Only then will your learning bear the fruits of true wisdom. Then you will soon be able to describe Krishna's divine pastimes without any inventions or fancies of your own.” (CC, Antya 5.131–133)

And then he showed how pure Sarasvati serves Gaura-Krishna even through the words of a fool or an enemy: thus she interprets as praise both Indra's reproaches and the abuse of Jarasandha and Shishupala. And Svarupa gave the poet's nandi-shloka a glorifying interpretation:

“There is no difference between Krishna and Jagannatha. They are one and the same Personality of Godhead. But here, in Sri Jagannatha Puri, the Supreme Lord appears before all as Daru-Brahman — God in a wooden and immovable form. Though Sri Chaitanya and Lord Jagannatha look different, Their identity is wholly one, and this is Krishna Himself, the one indivisible Absolute.” (CC, Antya 5.148–149)

Daru-brahma is the Lord Himself, appearing in a form of wood, not a piece of wood that needs to be “brought to life”; and the same Krishna, to save people, came as the moving (jangama) Brahman — Sri Chaitanya — and, traveling through the lands, saves all who cannot come to Jagannatha. For even one who utters Krishna's name while reviling Him attains liberation.

The poet accepted this instruction with bowed head. He prostrated himself before the devotees, surrendered to them, by their mercy received the Lord's darshana and mercy, gave up everything and stayed on in Nilachala among the devotees. Such is Svarupa as an acharya: without mercy he rejects the Mayavadis and rasabhasa, yet mercifully corrects one who has gone astray, and whoever accepts his merciful chastisement (kripa-shasana) surely attains the good.

“Svarupa's Raghu”

When Raghunatha Dasa, having finally left his worldly father and uncle, came to Nilachala, the Lord, touched by his zeal, entrusted him to Svarupa:

“I give Raghunatha Dasa wholly into your care. Please accept him as your son or servant. From now on there are three Raghunathas in My circle. So let this Raghunatha be known as Svarupa Damodara's Raghu.” (CC, Antya 6.202–203)

Saying this, the Lord took Raghunatha by the hand and placed his hand in Svarupa's. From then on he was called just that — “Svarupa's Raghu.”

Raghunatha often put his questions to the Lord through Svarupa and Govinda. When Svarupa asked the Lord what Raghunatha's duty was, the Lord told Raghunatha to accept Svarupa himself as his shiksha-guru: “He will tell you in full detail about the goal and the method of spiritual practice. I Myself do not know as much as he knows about all this” (CC, Antya 6.234). Having given Raghunatha His instructions — not to speak or hear of worldly things, not to eat tasty food or dress finely, to chant the Name without seeking honor, and to serve Radha-Krishna in the mind in Vrindavana — the Lord concluded, “You will learn the details from Svarupa.” By this the Lord declared Svarupa the eternal master-guru of the Madhva-Gaudiyas and the acharya of the whole truth of the goal and the path (sadhya and sadhana). Following him, Raghunatha attained the intimate service of Gaura-Krishna.

Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura explains that this “intimate service” is service in Vraja performed in the mind, in one's own spiritual form; and Dasa Gosvami performed it by entering the group of Lalita Devi, whom Svarupa is in the Vraja pastimes[7].

Svarupa watched over the whole life of his charge. When Raghunatha stopped inviting the Lord, Svarupa explained to the Lord that he had understood that food bought with his worldly father's money did not please Him. And when Raghunatha stopped standing at the Lion Gate waiting for alms and began going to the place where alms were distributed, Svarupa explained that he had come to regard standing at the gate as a waste of time. The stone from Govardhana and the gunja garland given him by the Lord Raghunatha worshiped as Gandharvika and Giridhari; at Svarupa's suggestion he offered Them sandesh that Govinda gave him.

At night Raghunatha would gather the rotten rice mahaprasada that the merchants at the Lion Gate threw out for the cows — not even the Tailanga cows would eat it — wash it and eat it as Krishna's spiritual remnants. Once Svarupa took a little and ate:

“Every day you relish this nectar, yet you never even offer it to us! How can you behave like this?” (CC, Antya 6.320)

Hearing of it from Govinda, the Lord came Himself and ate a handful: “What delicious treats you eat! But why don't you share them with Me?” When He took a second handful, Svarupa caught His hand and snatched the rice away: “It is not fitting for You to eat this.”

From this comes Svarupa's lesson: a sadhaka may, for the sake of his own love for Krishna, live in severe renunciation, but Hari, guru and the Vaishnavas are to be served with the best spiritual offerings, as masters. One must not “train in renunciation” Hari, guru and the Vaishnavas — keeping the Deities of Guru and Gauranga without food on Ekadashi, or worshiping them in the way they displayed austerity in their manifest pastimes to teach people — that is a great offense. The sadhaka's renunciation concerns himself alone.

In the Lord's final pastimes Svarupa was constantly at His side, and his “right hand” was Raghunatha Dasa. For sixteen years Raghunatha lived in Puri under Svarupa's care, and after the departure of the Lord and of Svarupa he went in grief to Vrindavana (CC, Adi 10.93).

Raghunatha was dear to Svarupa and always remembered him. In his verses he prays for love for Svarupa and Rupa with their companions, and in the “Sri Gauranga-stava-kalpataru” he recalls of the Lord: “By His mercy He drew me out when I had fallen into the forest-fire of great wealth, and joyfully entrusted me, a wretch, to His own Svarupa; He gave me the gunja necklace from His breast and the Govardhana stone so dear to Him” (11). And “Svarupa's treasury” — the Lord's pastimes — passed into his mouth (CC, Madhya 2.84; see below, on the kadcha).

Vallabha Bhatta and Gadadhara

When Vallabha Bhatta came to Nilachala and began to glorify the Lord, the Lord, concealing Himself, began to praise His devotees, and of Svarupa He said:

“In Svarupa Damodara all the rasas of divine love for Krishna are embodied. Through association with him I was able to understand madhura-rasa — the sweetness of the transcendental relationships of the lovers in Vrindavana. Unmixed and pure is the love of the cowherd girls of Vrindavana, the gopis. In it there is not a trace of worldly lust. The only aim of such love is to give happiness to Krishna. <…> The love of the cowherd girls of Vrindavana surpasses all kinds of devotion to God. In it the highest peak of service to Krishna is revealed. And Krishna Himself admits this when He calls Himself their eternal debtor. <…> Pure, unmixed love for Krishna is far higher than the love that arises from understanding His majesty and power. In the whole world there is no devotee better than Uddhava. Yet Uddhava himself longs to sprinkle his head with the dust of the feet of these cowherd girls of Vraja. All these truths I learned from Svarupa Damodara.” (CC, Antya 7.38–39, 42, 44–45)

Elsewhere Krishnadasa Kaviraja says that the Lord relished parental love with Paramananda Puri, friendship with Ramananda, service with Govinda and others, and the chief, conjugal rasa with Gadadhara, Jagadananda and Svarupa, and for that love felt Himself in their debt (CC, Madhya 2.78). Srila Bhaktisiddhanta in the “Anubhashya” confirms that they served the Lord in madhura-rasa. And Kavi Karnapura writes that Svarupa determined Gadadhara to be the Lakshmi of Vraja (GGD 148)[8].

When the Lord, testing the love of Gadadhara, who was well disposed toward Vallabha Bhatta, made a show of anger toward him and Gadadhara grew afraid, the Lord sent Svarupa and others for him. Svarupa said to Gadadhara: “The Lord was only testing you. Why didn't you come and tell Him everything, instead of suffering in fear?” Gadadhara replied that his duty was to bear any severity from his beloved Lord.

Advocate and Servant

Intolerant of deviations from siddhanta and of offenses, Svarupa always tried to draw the Lord's mercy to those who had stumbled for a time and to fulfil the devotees' requests. He interceded for Junior Haridasa; when the family of Bhavananda Raya was taken into custody because of his son Gopinatha Pattanayaka, Ramananda's kinsman, he and others begged the Lord to give up His indifference and intervene (CC, Antya 9.36); he urged the Lord to lie on the bedding Jagadananda had prepared. For all his strictness he was great in kindness.

Once in the Jagannatha temple the Lord held a kirtana in seven groups, revealing great majesty. Wishing to dance Himself, He told Svarupa to sing a line of an Oriya song, “jagamohana pari munda yau” — “let my head fall in the Jagamohana” — and, listening to it, displayed wondrous spiritual transformations.

When Namacharya Haridasa Thakura left his body before the Lord, Svarupa, the first of the intimate servants, surrounded him with nama-sankirtana and together with the Lord held a festival in honor of his departure. The Lord, spreading the end of His cloth, Himself begged mahaprasada from the merchants, and they were ready to give whole baskets; but Svarupa, knowing it would be hard for the Lord to carry, stopped them, sent the Lord home and took the festival upon himself. And when the Lord began to serve the prasada Himself, Svarupa held Him back and served it together with Jagadananda, Kashishvara and Shankara[9].

Jagadananda sewed a mattress and pillow for the Lord in saffron covers, gave them to Govinda and asked Svarupa too to see to it. Svarupa and Govinda made up the bed, but the Lord angrily asked who had done it, threw the bedding aside and lay down on banana leaves. Svarupa said that Jagadananda would be hurt, and the Lord in His “anger” pleaded that He was a renounced sannyasi. Then Svarupa,

expert in service, gathered dry banana leaves, split them with his nails until they were soft and stuffed the Lord's outer cloths with them — and so there was a mattress, and after long persuasion the Lord agreed to lie on it. This story shows more vividly than any other how well he knew how to serve the Lord. Jagadananda, hurt, wished to go to Mathura and asked Svarupa to obtain the Lord's permission; at Svarupa's request the Lord called Jagadananda and gave him instructions for the journey.

The Gambhira: Divine Madness

For the last twelve years in Puri the Lord was absorbed in the mood of Radha, and the depth of His feelings could be shared by only two — Svarupa and Ramananda:

“Day and night, in the company of only His two friends, Svarupa Damodara and Ramananda Raya, He relished verses and songs filled with descriptions of that intensity of feeling found only in loving relationships with Krishna.” (CC, Antya 20.4)

By day the Lord sang kirtana with the devotees, and at night with Svarupa and Ramananda He relished the truths of the pastimes and rasas of Radha and Krishna. With them He heard the songs of Chandidasa and Vidyapati, Jayadeva's “Gita-govinda,” the “Srimad-Bhagavatam,” Ramananda's play “Jagannatha-vallabha-nataka” and the verses of Bilvamangala's “Krishna-karnamrita.” Embracing them both around the neck, He sang of the incomparable glory of nama-sankirtana and of the summit of love in separation, and at times He would ask, “Tell Me, what am I to do, where am I to go to find Krishna?” — and they consoled Him: Svarupa sang, Ramananda recited verses. So they were constantly at His side in every surge of divine madness, consoling Him and nourishing His feelings — the eternal companions of His pastimes in separation.

Krishnadasa Kaviraja reveals that it was through Svarupa that the world learned the secret reason for the Lord's descent:

“This secret reason has three aspects. Svarupa Damodara has described it beautifully. Svarupa Gosvami is Sri Chaitanya's closest companion, and therefore he can reveal this subject better than anyone. <…> As Srimati Radhika, on seeing Uddhava, was in divine madness, so Sri Chaitanya was in the same mood day and night. At night He spoke incoherently, embracing Svarupa Damodara around the neck. In this blissful state He confided His heart's feelings to him. Svarupa Damodara would soothe Mahaprabhu, citing various songs and verses of scripture in tune with Sri Chaitanya's feelings.” (CC, Adi 4.104–105, 108–110)

Besides the other reasons, the Lord's descent had one more, principal reason — Krishna's own desire, the crown of rasikas, to taste the love of Radha; and this threefold secret was known to Svarupa, the most intimate of His companions.

One night in Kashi Mishra's house Svarupa, Govinda and the others lay down, having locked the three doors, while the Lord chanted the Names aloud all night. Suddenly the chanting stopped. Svarupa opened the door: all three doors were locked, and the Lord was gone. In alarm the devotees searched and found Him unconscious north of the Lion Gate: in separation His joints had come apart and His arms and legs had grown long; He rolled on the ground and wept. Svarupa and the devotees chanted the Names loudly into His ears until He came to Himself, and they carried Him home.

Another time, seeing the sand hill of Chataka by the sea, the Lord took it for Govardhana and in mahabhava ran toward it with the verse “hantayam adrir abala hari-dasa-varyo…” (Bhag. 10.21.18) on His lips. Svarupa and Jagadananda ran after Him. The eight spiritual transformations appeared in Him and He fell unconscious; Svarupa and the others chanted loudly and sprinkled Him with water. Partly returning to outer consciousness, He told Svarupa what He had experienced: “I was on Govardhana, I saw Krishna… why did you call Me back?”

When the feelings of the gopis searching for Krishna on the night of the rasa dance awoke in the Lord, He asked Svarupa to sing a fitting song, and Svarupa began “rase harim iha vihita-vilasam” (“Gita-govinda,” 2.2). The Lord danced, and all eight spiritual transformations appeared in Him at once; seeing how deeply He was shaken, Svarupa stopped singing.

At that time Shivananda Sena came to the Lord with his son, the boy Paramananda Puri-dasa. However much the Lord and his father asked, the boy would not utter Krishna's name, and the Lord was amazed: “I have made the whole world, down to the immovable beings, chant the Name, yet this little one I could not!” Svarupa explained: “You gave him the mantra of the Name, and he does not want to reveal it before others — he chants it in his mind.” And so it proved: one day, at the Lord's word, the seven-year-old boy at once composed a verse on Krishna's victory (this is the future Kavi Karnapura).

The Lord remained day and night in divine madness. Once He talked of Krishna half the night with Svarupa and Ramananda: whenever some feeling awoke in Him, Svarupa sang a song in tune with it, and Ramananda recited verses of Vidyapati, Chandidasa and the “Gita-govinda” in tune with it (CC, Antya 17.5–6); then, having put the Lord to rest, both went home. At midnight the Lord, hearing Krishna's flute, crossed three walls without opening the doors and fell unconscious south of the Lion Gate, among the Tailanga cows. Govinda, not hearing Him, called Svarupa; with a lamp and the devotees Svarupa found the Lord among the cows, drawn in like a tortoise. They carried Him home with difficulty and brought Him back to consciousness with loud kirtana; half-conscious, He told Svarupa of His state and lamented that He no longer heard the flute. Understanding His mood, Svarupa recited the verse “ka stry anga te…” (Bhag. 10.29.40), and hearing it from Svarupa's lips, the Lord, absorbed in the feelings of the gopis, began to speak in chitra-jalpa. And when, returning to outer consciousness, He asked, “Svarupa, sing something sweet,” Svarupa sang songs of Vidyapati and the “Gita-govinda,” and hearing them the Lord grew calm (CC, Antya 17.62).

Krishnadasa Kaviraja confesses that what Sri Krishna Chaitanya relished is known only to Svarupa and his circle, while an insignificant soul describing it touches only a drop — for the sake of his own purification (CC, Antya 18.18–23).

On an autumn moonlit night the Lord went from Aitota to the sea, took it for the Yamuna, entered the water, and the waves carried Him toward Konarak. A fisherman pulled Him out with his net, thinking he had caught a big fish, and on touching Him was filled with divine love; deciding that a ghost had possessed him, he went looking for an exorcist. Svarupa and the devotees, searching for the Lord along the shore, met the fisherman, questioned him and understood that it was he who had pulled the Lord out. Svarupa said, “I am a great exorcist, I know how to drive out ghosts,” recited a mantra, placed his hand on the man's head, slapped him three times and announced, “The ghost is gone.” Having calmed him, he explained: “This is no ghost, but the Supreme Lord Himself, Sri Krishna Chaitanya. In ecstasy He threw Himself into the sea, and by His touch love for Krishna has awakened in you”[10].

Svarupa labored long to bring the Lord back to consciousness. Half-conscious, the Lord spoke in chitra-jalpa, and on coming to Himself asked, “Why have you brought Me here?” Svarupa told Him everything, and the Lord told of His own experience; then Svarupa bathed Him and brought Him home.

When Jagadananda returned to Nilachala by way of Navadvipa and Shantipura, Advaita sent a riddle through him. When Svarupa asked about it, the Lord hinted that the purpose of His descent was fulfilled and His pastimes would soon be withdrawn. Svarupa's heart grew heavy with sorrow, and from that day the Lord's separation from Krishna grew still stronger.

On the full moon of Vaishakha the Lord entered the Jagannatha-vallabha garden at night with the devotees, saw Krishna there beneath an ashoka tree, and when He, smiling, vanished, fell unconscious and, breathing His fragrance, became absorbed in the divine madness of Radha. Till morning Svarupa

and Ramananda sang and the Lord danced; in the morning they brought Him back to outer consciousness by various means (CC, Antya 19.78–100).

The Lord gave His last instructions to Svarupa and Ramananda — that harinama-sankirtana is the highest means in the age of Kali — and then spoke the “Shikshashtaka”; this, like the songs of Vidyapati and Chandidasa, the “Krishna-karnamrita” and the “Gita-govinda,” He relished day and night with the two of them.

The Kadcha and His Legacy

Of all the Lord's devotees only “three and a half” belonged to the inner circle of Srimati Radhika:

“These three are Svarupa Damodara, Ramananda Raya and Shikhi Mahiti, and the half is his sister Madhavi.” (CC, Antya 2.106)

The Lord's early pastimes were recorded by Murari Gupta, the final ones by Svarupa Damodara:

“The deeds of Sri Chaitanya in the Adi-lila are described in brief by Murari Gupta. And Sri Chaitanya's final pastimes were described in the form of brief notes by Svarupa Damodara (Mahaprabhu's secretary).” (CC, Adi 13.15–16)

On the basis of Murari Gupta's kadcha the pastimes were described by Vrindavana Dasa, Lochana Dasa and others. And the final pastimes, full of love in separation, which Svarupa recorded in his kadcha and passed on to “Svarupa's Raghunatha,” became the foundation of the bhajana of the Svarupa-Rupanuga sampradaya.

Krishnadasa Kaviraja tells what he relied on in describing these pastimes:

“Svarupa Damodara and Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami described these pastimes of Sri Chaitanya in their diaries. In those days only these two lived beside Sri Chaitanya, while all the other biographers were elsewhere. <…> Svarupa Damodara usually kept his notes brief, while Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami recorded the Lord's deeds in detail.” (CC, Antya 14.7–8, 10)

They recorded the Lord's experiences moment by moment: Svarupa as the composer of the sutras, Raghunatha as their commentator, and Kaviraja unfolded their details in his book like a detailed commentary.

Murari's notes have survived, but Svarupa's kadcha the Vaishnavas heard only from the lips of Raghunatha Dasa. Krishnadasa Kaviraja writes: “The pastimes of Sri Chaitanya are like the most beautiful jewels. Svarupa Damodara keeps them in the treasury of his heart. He bestowed this knowledge on Raghunatha Dasa, and he retold it to me” (CC, Madhya 2.84). Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura explains that Svarupa's kadcha consists of brief Sanskrit verses on the Lord's final pastimes, which Raghunatha learned by heart; it has never been published as a book, and its essence entered the “Chaitanya-charitamrita.” In the kadcha Svarupa also recorded the Lord's conversations with Ramananda, and from these Kaviraja unfolded them.

In the “Jaiva-dharma” (ch. 39) Bhaktivinoda Thakura relates that the Lord told Svarupa to preach worship full of rasa, and at this command he composed a kadcha in two parts. The inner path of rasopasana he passed on “by word of mouth” to Dasa Gosvami, and it entered Raghunatha's books; the outer path he passed on to Vakreshvara Pandita. So Svarupa's method of worship in madhura-rasa spread along two lines: from Raghunatha to Krishnadasa Kaviraja, and from Vakreshvara to Gopala Guru Gosvami, who kept Svarupa's teaching in his memory and sat, as the “Jaiva-dharma” (ch. 26) pictures him, in his seat[11]. In the Gambhira the Lord's quilt, sewn by Svarupa or by Jagadananda, is kept to this day.

With verses from Svarupa's kadcha Krishnadasa Kaviraja opens the “Chaitanya-charitamrita”: “radha-krishna-pranaya- vikritir…,” “sri-radhayah pranaya-mahima…,” then “sankarshanah karana-toya-shayi…” and five more verses on Nityananda, two on Advaita and a verse on the Pancha-tattva (CC, Adi 1.5–14). Following Svarupa, Kaviraja also describes Nityananda in the fifth chapter as vibhu.

Had Svarupa not preserved the intimate final pastimes in his kadcha “on the lips” of Raghunatha, no one would have known the chief purpose of Gaura's appearance. Murari's kadcha, Vrindavana Dasa's “Chaitanya-bhagavata” and Lochana Dasa's “Chaitanya-mangala” tell of the life of the Lord and His devotees; but only Svarupa's kadcha, which Raghunatha knew by heart and which by Kaviraja's mercy the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” unfolded, revealed the special path of bhajana that fulfils Chaitanya's innermost desire. By Svarupa's mercy the Gaudiya devotees came to know the chief purpose and the secret reason of Gaurasundara's descent and the nature of Nityananda, Advaita and the Pancha-tattva; the soul can learn its eternal spiritual form and enter the teaching of Rupa and Raghunatha; the Lord's thoughts and intimate feelings became accessible to all Gaudiya Vaishnavas.

The siddhantas revealed by Svarupa, Rupa and Raghunatha are the secret siddhantas of the Lord's heart. The deep truths that the Lord spoke through the mouth of Ramananda, Svarupa, his inseparable friend, set down in his kadcha of the Lord's final pastimes and explained through the pastimes. Kavi Karnapura says that the identifications of the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” too are taken from the words of the Lord Himself and His closest companions — Svarupa Damodara, Murari Gupta and others.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati traced his shiksha-parampara thus: Sri Chaitanya — Svarupa Damodara — Rupa and Sanatana (with Raghunatha Dasa, Raghunatha Bhatta and Gopala Bhatta) — Jiva — Krishnadasa Kaviraja… Bhaktisiddhanta himself was called the best of the followers of Svarupa and Rupa, and his behest was, “Be a servant of the followers of Svarupa and Rupa.” All our former gurus called themselves followers of Svarupa and Rupa, and whoever is counted in the circle of Svarupa, Rupa and Raghunatha has entered the intimate bhajana of Gaurasundara. That is why the Vaishnavas honor Svarupa as the eternal “lord of the Madhva-Gaudiyas.”

Departure

Svarupa Damodara left this world in Purushottama soon after the Lord's withdrawal, on the day of Jagannatha's Ratha-yatra — the shukla-dvitiya of the month of Ashadha. In our calendar this is the Gaura-dvitiya of the month of Vamana — the Disappearance Day of Srila Svarupa Damodara Gosvami, observed together with the Ratha-yatra[12]. The biographies do not give the year of his departure, nor the day of his appearance.

Lalita and Vishakha

Who Svarupa is in Krishna's eternal pastimes, Kaviraja Gosvami shows through his service in the Lord's last pastimes:

“As formerly Lalita, Her chief friend, consoled Srimati Radharani, so now Svarupa Damodara sustained the life of Sri Chaitanya, who was living Radharani's heart-rending love.” (CC, Antya 6.10)

So the acharyas understand him too. Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura calls Svarupa Lalita Devi in the Vraja pastimes (see above, on Raghunatha); and the biographies say that Gaurasundara's “second self” is in the Vraja pastimes Lalita Devi, Radhika's “second self,” and that Ramananda is Vishakha. This is called the prevailing view in the Gaudiya sampradaya. Srila B. R. Sridhar Maharaj, in “The Golden Volcano of Divine Love” (section “Sri Gauranga-avatara”), says that Svarupa Damodara Prabhu, Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu's personal secretary, is considered to be Lalita-sakhi, the nearest friend of Srimati

Radharani in the pastimes of Krishna. As Lalita and Vishakha are Radha's closest friends, so Svarupa and Ramananda are Sri Chaitanya's closest companions[13].

However his role in the eternal pastimes is named, one thing is clear: his nature is service in madhura-rasa, in the mood of a sakhi of Radha. That is why he became the “second self” of the Lord, who came to taste Radha's love, and why to him alone was revealed all that the Lord experienced in separation.

1. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati in the “Anubhashya” (on CC, Adi 4.105) writes otherwise: Purushottama Bhattacharya wished to renounce the world even before the Lord's sannyasa, went to Benares and became a brahmachari under a Dashanami sannyasi with the name Damodara Svarupa; he did not complete the rites of sannyasa, came to Nilachala and spent the rest of his life at the Lord's feet, and only by his mercy did the devotees learn the Lord's secret purpose. According to the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” (Madhya 10.104), the “Prema-vilasa” and most biographies, he went to Kashi after seeing the Lord's sannyasa.

2. According to this interpretation of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, he accepted only brahmacharya among the Dashanamis; according to the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” (Madhya 10.104, 108) and the biographies, it was sannyasa, but without the yogapatta.

3. Their first meeting is told differently. According to one biography, Svarupa first met Ramananda when the latter came to Puri with King Prataparudra; according to another, Ramananda arrived from Vidyanagara at about the same time as Svarupa came.

4. According to another account, Svarupa, having pushed the brahmana out of the temple, at once went back to the Lord himself and asked Him to forgive the man.

5. According to one biography he “left his body in Sri-kshetra”; according to the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” (Antya 2.158), in a holy place, that is, at Prayaga, at the Triveni.

6. This interpretation is the poet's error, which Svarupa will at once reject. The words “body” and “soul” are not the trouble in themselves: Lord Jagannatha is Krishna Himself, appearing in a form of wood (daru-brahma), not an image to be “brought to life.” The poet's mistake is that he divided Jagannatha and Gaura as a body and the soul living in it, as if Jagannatha were inert matter and Chaitanya one of the souls; but in God there is no difference between His body and Himself.

7. On the identification of Svarupa with Lalita and the other identification of the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika,” see the section “Lalita and Vishakha” and note 13.

8. One biography ascribes these words to Kaviraja; they are in Kavi Karnapura's “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika,” where Gadadhara is also called Sri Radha (147). According to another biography, “Svarupa's records” confirm that Gadadhara is Radha.

9. According to another account, Svarupa himself brought the prasada for the festival from the temple and served it together with Jagadananda and others; and over Haridasa's body Svarupa chanted the Names while Vakreshvara danced.

10. According to another account, Svarupa saw the fisherman on the shore with the Lord on his shoulders and explained to him who this was, but still had to slap him several times to calm him; then loud chanting of the Names brought the Lord back to consciousness.

11. Gopala Guru was a disciple of Vakreshvara; according to one biography he was trained in rasa under Svarupa and Raghunatha Dasa, and in one place another biography calls him “a disciple of Svarupa Damodara” — probably by mistake.

12. According to one biography, he departed “on the second day from the full moon of the month of Ashadha” — apparently a garbled “shukla-dvitiya”; another speaks only of the day of the Ratha-yatra, soon after the Lord's withdrawal.

13. Kavi Karnapura in the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” calls Svarupa Vishakha: “Vishakha, who once in Vraja taught Radha the arts, is now Svarupa Gosvami, who delights in those same moods” (GGD 160). The comparison in the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” (Antya 6.10) and the word of the acharyas point to Lalita; we give both identifications without blending them.